

However, the educational institutions in India are focused on theoretical education. The industry needs manpower which has practical exposure to telecom systems. So the curriculum of educational institutions needs to be changed to include more industry-oriented education and training.

Sinha says, "The educational institutes in India are trying to keep pace with the evolving technology, but there is a lot of scope for development, definitely. They need to understand the demand of the changing time and evolving technology and offer forward-looking courses to the students. Those institutes which provide cutting-edge environment are sustaining. The educational institutes have to see more from the perspective of what will be the scenario three years henceforth."

"I would like to see more of business- and industry-oriented education being incorporated in the syllabus. If that integration does not happen, it is a problem. There is still no course available for architects, whereas in real world everybody needs that. There is a dearth of skilled talent in the telecom industry. There is a need of people in many areas. Apart from talent, the required skill set is also important and that's the biggest challenge we face in the industry today," he adds.

Kabra says, "Telecom organisations look for engineers who have some hands-on experience in managing the equipment. But these resources are virtually non-existent as the telecom infrastructure equipment are very expensive to own for any educational institution. So the industry has to settle with engineers having at least good grasp of theoretical engineering concepts and good communication skills."

There are companies like Cognitel which help the colleges to provide hands-on training to the students in order to make them industry-ready.

Kabra explains, "We have a setup where students undergo real training. It is not possible for the colleges to tie up with companies for hands-on training of their students. We come in as a solution for colleges which want to

bring industry-ready products."

K.P. Unnikrishnan, marketing director (Asia Pacific), Brocade, endorses such trainings by saying, "India has the benefit of having one of the youngest and most skilled workforce coming into the industry. With some of the best universities and colleges around, this is taken care of. But what the academia and students should ensure is that they are up-to-date with latest technologies like cloud."

Sky is the limit

Experts call telecom the second IT industry of India.

Sinha highlights: "If you look at the larger picture, the number of engineers coming out of the colleges and the number of vacant positions even out. But if you break down the figures, that's where the problem is. Like, if you say 'I have 5000 engineers coming out,' 1000 out of 5000 will be in hardware engineering. Now if you ask whether I have jobs for a thousand hardware engineers, I will say 'no' because perhaps only a hundred of them are familiar with telecom business operations."

India has been a growth market for telecommunication companies from across the globe. Employees having the desired skillset are valued by companies in the business.

Reema Malhotra says, "Nokia Siemens Networks is viewed as talent incubator by the telecom industry. We continue to drive innovation and serve India's telecom industry. We provide our employees opportunities to engage with people from around the world, providing valuable opportunities to share and

exchange ideas, values and cultures. Through the use of advanced tools and applications supporting virtual teaming, collaboration and remote working, Nokia Siemens Networks provides more opportunities to create an ideal work environment and facilitates the development of global work teams. Our employment policies give employees the support as and when they need. We give the training that employees need to meet the challenges of a dynamic industry. We aim to provide employees with the tools and materials that will help develop their career and encourage personal development."

Companies in telecom work to imbibe a culture in their organisations where employees are encouraged to take cross-functional roles. This pro-

